

TIPS FOR WRITING A PERSONAL STATEMENT

A personal statement summarizes your goals and reasons for applying to graduate school or a prestigious fellowship. It allows you to articulate your professional vision and showcase your writing skills.

Factors to consider before you begin:

RESEARCH PROGRAMS EXTENSIVELY

- Research as much as you can about the schools/fellowships to which you are applying. Apply to programs that fit your identity as a future professional and demonstrate in your essay how the specific program suits your goals (see specifics below). For graduate school, be aware of what research interests and specialties the faculty members have. Talk to advisors, professors, and alumni familiar with the school or program to find out as much information as possible.
- Make sure you find out if your discipline has a centralized application system. If your degree has a centralized application system, you should be general about the schools you apply to in these systems. However, if your school is not participating in the centralized system or when you have to fill out secondary applications, then you can and should be specific about a particular school.

REVIEW ALL APPLICATION INSTRUCTIONS

- Follow the instructions both in terms of length limitations and addressing ALL aspects of each question. If the instructions are open-ended - for example, "Write an autobiographical essay." - focus on summarizing the most significant events (not ALL of the experiences) that helped shape you as a person and influenced your ambitions to go to graduate school or pursue a fellowship opportunity. Give specific details that illustrate your general point. Admissions representatives read hundreds of essays; yours needs to stand out!

UNDERSTANDING THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A PERSONAL STATEMENT AND A STATEMENT OF PURPOSE

- If you're applying for a Master's or Ph.D. program, you'll likely write a statement of purpose. This statement shows who you are, why you're applying, why you're a good candidate, and what you want to do in the future. It should, in turn, make clear your fit for the program. You'll want to clearly articulate your motivation for pursuing an advanced degree and how it will influence your career path. The statement of purpose reflects not only who you are as a candidate but also your writing abilities. The more academic the degree, the more they will want you to focus on academic achievements and research in your statement of purpose.
- If you're applying for a medical or law school program, you'll probably be writing a personal statement. A personal statement reflects who you are. It is less formal and more personal; write it in a way that lets the reader get to know you – your background, your hopes and dreams, your practical experience, your challenges, and the hardships you have overcome. As with the statement of purpose, you'll want the reader to come away with a clear sense of your commitment to the field. Additionally, you'll aim to showcase the qualities you have that will help you succeed in that program or that field.

WRITING YOUR STATEMENT

When writing your statement for a 'prestigious fellowship' or graduate school, note that the competition will be intense. It requires not only high academic achievement but also evidence of educational and personal leadership. Your essay/ personal statement needs to reflect that.

Approach writing a personal statement in the same way you would approach an assignment:

When you begin a paper for a college course, you have an awareness of your need to write formally, proofread, and address the specific assignment the professor has given. Approach your statement with the same seriousness. Ask yourself the following questions: Who is my audience? What is this program looking for? Did I answer all the specific questions?



CONSIDER YOUR AUDIENCE

Employ a professional tone when striving to convince your audience to select you. Try to appeal to your program-specific criteria and strengths while relating examples of your background. Be sure to clarify culturally specific terms and organizations. Spell out the full title of the organization rather than using the acronym. Think about what makes you stand out as an individual among hundreds of other applicants: You will be competing with many qualified peers for acceptance. Considering the applicant pool, what can you say about your experience and qualifications that other students cannot say about themselves? What details can you give that will make you memorable to an admission representative or selection committee? What makes you unique? At the end of reading your statement, the committee should understand your interest/motivation, abilities, distinguishing factors, and fit.

GIVE YOURSELF AMPLE TIME TO WORK ON YOUR STATEMENT

A personal statement, like many other types of writing, should be written in multiple drafts. Your first draft should not be your final product! Give yourself ample time to seek feedback from the Writing Center, the Shevet Glaubach Center for Career Strategy and Professional Development, faculty, and others who could be helpful. Deadlines for Fellowships and graduate schools are critical and seldom extended. If the application or letters of recommendation are late, the admissions office will not consider the application.

WRITING PROCESS

One way to start the writing process is to sit down and get all your thoughts on paper. Start by only listing the elements you are considering including in your statement. Take a break from writing for a day or more; when you come back to your notes with fresh eyes, organize your thoughts logically. Reviewing your work in stages will help you determine what part of your draft is essential and what details to exclude. Strive for quality, not quantity; rather than listing many biographical details, develop two or three examples of your most recent and relevant research projects or professional experiences that will set you apart from other applicants. Developing examples should include reflecting upon and evaluating how each experience impacted your decision to pursue your future goals. A good question to ask yourself is: "What did I learn about myself, about others, or about my future career from each experience I choose?"

CREATE A STRONG INTRODUCTION AND CONCLUSION

If you find writing introductions troublesome, work on your introduction after you finish your essay. Once you have developed your significant life experiences, include them in your essay's body, consider what all the experiences show about you. How can you introduce these examples in a comprehensive way that reflects you? Is there a common theme that emerges which may tie your statement together? For your conclusion, make sure that the last sentence of your essay gives completion to your statement.

BE POSITIVE

A personal statement is a space for you to highlight your accomplishments and strengths. Avoid apologizing for your grade point average or complaining about a teacher who discouraged you. Focus on the positive elements of your background.

USE SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

Avoid superlatives and absolute terms like "none" or "never." Rather than saying, "I have always wanted to be a speech therapist," be more specific, contextualize it: "Having a grandmother who suffered a stroke has helped me value the importance of speech therapy in daily life." Also, try to avoid repetition in your essay.

BEFORE FINALIZING YOUR DRAFT

Proofread your work. Check your statement for spelling and grammatical errors. Utilize the Writing Center, the Shevet Glaubach Center (SGC), faculty, a trusted family member, or friend to proofread. Ensure you are spelling the school/fellowship's name correctly and referring to the program you are applying to specifically. By working with campus resources, you will get help from experienced advisors who can guide you through various elements of the personal statement writing process.



THINGS TO AVOID

Sounding too casual or cliché. The following statement relies on a figure of speech and is unoriginal: "After receiving an A on a challenging philosophy paper, it hit me like a ton of bricks: I want to practice law!" While this example conveys the writer's enthusiasm, the writer could be more precise by avoiding the cliché "it hit me like a ton of bricks." A specific example of being passionate about law results in an original and compelling sentence: "As a philosophy major, I have found that the experience of analyzing arguments and identifying counterarguments has solidified my interest in law and refined my ability as a critical thinker."

Using the second-person pronoun, "you." The following sentence is vague and could confuse a reader: "When you think of a career choice, you should commit yourself to something you love." Who is "you"? Instead of directing a general statement to an unspecified audience, speak from a place of personal experience: "I want to commit myself to social work because I find that helping others cope is very rewarding." Remember, it is a personal statement.

Avoid short-cuts. Remember that a personal statement is a formal piece of writing; therefore, it is good to avoid contractions and abbreviations whenever possible when writing for a professional audience. Opt for "The Benjamin N. Cardozo School of Law will offer me hands-on learning and career-building connections," instead of "Cardozo will offer me hands-on learning to succeed in my future career."

MAINTAIN GENERAL FORMATTING GUIDELINES

- 12-point Times New Roman Font
- 1 – inch margins on all sides
- 1 – 1.5 line spacing

This format will make your writing more comfortable to read. You will not get bonus points for standing out with your visual formatting. It is going to benefit you much more to focus on wowing the reader with your actual content.

